

direct connections with stakeholders,” says Suraj Sudhi, product owner, SAP Labs India.

NGOs and volunteers can sign up on Charitra (www.charitra.in) for free. NGOs can then post their project details including descriptions and requirements, which go online after moderator approval. Donors or volunteers can sign up to know about various projects or causes to participate in. If they are interested in a project, they can register their ‘promise’ to donate or participate. However, the actual fulfilment of the project requirements is offline, with the NGO and the volunteer deciding together how to deliver on the promises made.

“We believe technology is a key enabler for bringing about change, which drives positive impact beyond businesses. Taking this thought forward, the SAP Labs team in India developed Charitra—one of SAP’s first consumer applications using ‘design thinking.’ Design thinking is an approach that views a problem from three key angles: desirability, feasibility and viability. Charitra is also built on the SAP HANA platform and runs on the cloud,” says Sudhi.

Harnessing the capabilities of SAP HANA, as well as cloud and mobile technologies, Charitra helps to drive positive impact in people’s daily lives. Charitra, since its launch towards the end of 2011, has over 17,000 users, 100+ NGOs and 80+ educational institutions as part of the system.

Mobile solution to detect and cure epidemics

Social tag: Epidemics, spread, information, cure

Tech tags: Mobile app, simple forms

Startled by the outbreak of Leptospirosis in Sri Lanka and Chikungunya in Tamil Nadu around 2007-08, researchers from IIT Madras’ Rural Technology Business Incubator (RTBI) and LIRNEasia in Sri Lanka set about exploring whether the mobile phone, which was gaining ground during that time, could be used to detect the outbreak of an epidemic and also send



Village health nurses undergoing training about RTBP

out information pertaining to its cure to health workers across geographies.

Detecting an epidemic requires identification of similar cases reported across a region. This is quite difficult with a system that relies mostly on paper-based records.

“Health workers, especially nurses in rural areas are quite over-worked. On top of that, they are burdened with a considerable amount of paper work too. But by the time these papers reach the concerned officers, get fed into a system and analysed, the epidemic would have blown up,” says Suma Prashant, deputy director and senior vice president (exploratory initiatives) of IITM’s RTBI.

The research, funded by a grant from the International Development Research Centre of Canada, was called the Real-Time Biosurveillance Program (RTBP). It aimed to introduce the latest technology to health departments in Tamil Nadu and Sri Lanka to complement the existing disease surveillance and notification systems.

“With great support from the secretary of the government of Tamil Nadu and the deputy director of Health Services, Sivaganga, during that time, RTBI set about exploring various alternatives including the tech architecture, the kind of phones to be used and so on. We piloted the solution in the Sivaganga district in Tamil Nadu, with four public health centres, 25 nurses and 200 villages within its purview,” says Prashant.

The RTBP system involves digitising all clinical health records and analysing them in nearly real time to detect unusual events, and forward health workers before the diseases reach epidemic levels. At the heart of the solution is the mHealthSurvey mobile phone application, which enables health

workers to feed information such as patient case, disease and syndrome, using a very simple form on a low-cost Java-enabled mobile phone.

This information is fed into the T-Cube Web interface, which is a browser-based software tool that uses the T-Cube data structure for fast retrieval and display of large-scale multivariate time series and spatial information. The interface allows the user to execute complex queries quickly and run various types of comprehensive statistical tests on the loaded data.

The Sahana messaging/alerting module is then used to disseminate information to health workers and officials if any suspicious trend is spotted. The system can also be used to share information about cures for the same.

Although the pilots were successful, the implementation did not take off to scale but currently, they are in a position to implement RTBP in any location, if required, and are also exploring ways to use a similar system for other public healthcare services such as disease notification, treatment adherence system, and maternal and child health in rural areas.

Ensuring employees reach home safe

Social tag: Employee safety

Tech tag: Mobile app, location services, GPS, maps, SMS

Employee security, especially women’s security, has become a key social concern in India, especially in light of